Co-operative Bank of Kenya: UI/UX Designer

Stage 1: Practical assessment

Date	Thursday, 5 November 2026
Time	14:00 (aim to arrive by 13:30)
Venue	The Hive, CIC Plaza II, Ground Floor, Mara Road, Upper Hill, Nairobi
Contact	Lavinia Wasawo (HR & Administration): lwasawo@co-opbank.co.ke, +254 711 013 482

0. What the job ad tells us (ref UI-UX/YFS/2026)

You'd report to the Technical Lead, Youth Financial Services Division. The practical will very likely involve **young customers**: students, first jobbers, gig workers and young entrepreneurs aged roughly 18–35. Prepare for youth-focused briefs as well as general banking ones.

What they're looking for, and how to show it on the day:

The ad says	Show it in the practical
"Mad visual design skills... colour, typography, a good sketch... push creative boundaries"	Make the hi-fi screens polished. Use a deliberate type scale, a restrained colour palette and real-looking content. **Start with paper sketches and show them.** Take one bold creative swing (a micro-interaction, a playful empty state) while staying on-brand.
"Interaction models, user task flows, UI specifications"	Put a clear flow diagram on the canvas and add short spec notes to key components (states, spacing, behaviour).
"Information architecture... site maps"	If the brief covers a feature area, sketch a quick site map showing where it sits in the app.
"Facilitate design thinking sessions... building consensus with stakeholders"	In your presentation, say how you'd run a workshop to check the design with business, tech and risk teams. Name the methods: HMW questions, crazy 8s, dot voting.
"Analyse usability test results... surveys, interviews, observations"	End with a testing plan: 5 users, the tasks, what you'd measure.
"Technically feasible... work with technical leads"	Call out constraints: API latency, M-Pesa callbacks, USSD fallback, low-end devices.
"Resolve conflicts... prioritisation and trade-off decisions"	State one trade-off you made explicitly (for example security vs speed) and why.
"UI guidelines, standards... cohesive experiences"	Build with reusable components and styles in Figma (colour and text styles, auto layout). Assessors may open your file and look.
"Figma (essential), FigJam, Miro"	Use Figma confidently: components, variants, auto layout, prototype links. Do the flow in FigJam if time allows.
"Scope and estimate... rapidly produce deliverables"	Write your time plan at the top of the canvas and stick to it. Finished and focused beats ambitious and incomplete.

Youth banking context to prepare

- Young Kenyan users already expect M-Pesa, Fuliza and app-first fintechs such as M-Shwari, KCB M-Pesa, Chipper Cash and Wise. They compare Co-op's app with these, not with other banks.
- Recurring youth needs:
  - saving towards goals (fees, a laptop, rent)
  - budgeting and spending insights
  - small loans with transparent pricing
  - splitting bills with friends
  - getting paid for gig or freelance work
  - building a credit history
  - financial literacy
- Design cues that work: friendly, plain language (Sheng or Swahili touches, used sparingly), progress visuals, gentle nudges and celebration moments, and fast onboarding with ID plus selfie.
- Be careful with: gamification that pushes people into borrowing, hidden fees, and dark patterns. Responsible lending is a strong point to make in a bank interview.

Second practice brief: youth-focused (90 minutes)

> **Brief:** Co-op Bank wants to attract university students and first-time earners (18–25). Design a **savings goals** feature in the mobile app. A user can create a goal (for example "Laptop – KES 60,000 by March"), save automatically (a fixed amount weekly, or round-ups from M-Pesa transactions), track progress, and withdraw early with a clear explanation of any penalty or lost interest.
>
> **Users:** Achieng, 20, a second-year student in Eldoret who gets HELB money and some cash from home and keeps running out mid-semester. Kevin, 24, a junior developer in Nairobi on his first salary who wants to save for rent and a holiday.
>
> **Deliver:**
>
> - a site map showing where Goals sits in the app
> - a user flow for creating a goal
> - 6–8 hi-fi screens: onboarding to Goals, create a goal, choose a savings rule, the goal dashboard, a milestone celebration, and early withdrawal with a confirmation
> - one empty state and one error state
> - how you'd test it, and a success metric
>
> **Stretch:** a "save together" group goal, for a trip or a chama-style group.

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1. Confirmation reply (send today, Reply All)

> **Subject:** RE: Practical Assessment – UI/UX Designer
>
> Dear Lavinia,
>
> Thank you for the invitation. I confirm that I will attend the practical assessment for the UI/UX Designer role on Thursday, 5th November 2026 at 14:00 at The Hive, CIC Plaza II, Upper Hill.
>
> I will bring my laptop and my original National ID.
>
> Is there any specific software you would like me to have installed for the assessment (for example Figma desktop)? Will internet access be available on site?
>
> I look forward to meeting you and the team.
>
> Kind regards, Joshua [Surname] [Phone number]

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2. Checklist for the day

- ❑ Original National ID
- ❑ Laptop, fully charged, plus charger
- ❑ Mouse (wireless or wired)
- ❑ Phone hotspot, in case the venue Wi-Fi is slow or locked down
- ❑ **Work offline too:** Figma desktop installed and signed in, and a backup tool in case Figma is unavailable (Penpot, or Adobe XD if you have it)
- ❑ Your own UI kit or wireframe kit saved offline, plus fonts installed (Inter, Roboto)
- ❑ Notebook and pen for quick sketching before you go digital
- ❑ Portfolio open in a browser tab and saved as a PDF on the desktop
- ❑ Desktop cleared of personal files and notifications muted (you may be asked to screen-share or present)
- ❑ Travel: Upper Hill traffic is heavy around lunchtime, so leave early

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3. What the practical will probably test

Bank UI/UX practicals usually last 1–3 hours. Expect one of these:

1. **Redesign an existing flow**, for example on the MCo-opCash app or Co-op internet banking: send money, pay bills or buy airtime, open an account, apply for a loan, check a statement.
2. **Design a new feature from a short brief**, for example savings goals, card controls (freeze/unfreeze), a loan eligibility checker, or onboarding for a new customer.
3. **Critique a screen or flow**: find usability problems and propose fixes.
4. **Present your work**: a 5–10 minute walkthrough of your decisions.

A process you can fit into a timed brief

Split your time roughly like this:

Time	Step
10%	**Understand the brief.** Restate the problem, users, constraints and success metric in a single sentence each. Write down your assumptions.

Time	Step
15%	**User and flow.** Write 1–2 personas in a few words each, for example a "Sacco member in Kisumu on a low-end Android phone" and a "young professional in Nairobi using the app daily". Map the user flow with every step.
15%	**Sketch / low-fi.** Make quick wireframes of the key screens. Pick one direction.
45%	**Hi-fi.** Design 3–6 key screens with consistent components, including empty, error, loading and success states.
15%	**Present.** Cover the problem, users, flow, screens, edge cases, how you'd test it, and the metrics you'd track.

Show your thinking on the canvas: label your assumptions, the flow and the reasons for each decision. Assessors grade how you work as well as the final screens.

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4. Banking UX points to show you understand

Trust and security

- Show a clear confirmation screen before any money moves: amount, recipient name and account, fees, total.
- Ask for PIN or biometric login at the right moments without adding friction everywhere.
- Mask sensitive data (account numbers, balance hide/show toggle).
- Make it easy to recognise fraud and report it ("This wasn't me").

Kenyan context

- Integration with M-Pesa (paybill, till, send to M-Pesa) is central to everyday banking.
- Many customers use low-end Android devices on unstable data, so keep screens light and design offline/retry states. Remember USSD (*667#) users exist too.
- Support Swahili and English, and use plain language rather than banking jargon.
- Co-op's customer base includes Saccos, co-operatives, farmers and diaspora customers, so think beyond the urban young professional.
- Use KES formatting consistently (KES 1,250.00).

Accessibility (WCAG 2.1 AA)

- Text contrast of at least 4.5:1, tap targets of at least 44×44 px, and labels that don't rely on colour alone.
- Error messages say what went wrong and how to fix it.
- Layouts work with large text and screen readers.

Brand

- Co-op Bank's brand colour is green. Use it for primary actions and keep the palette restrained. Don't copy their logo or assets unless the brief provides them.

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5. Questions to prepare answers for

- Walk us through a project from your portfolio. What was the problem, what was your role, what did you do and what was the outcome?

- How do you design when you have no time for user research?
- How do you handle pushback from developers or business stakeholders?
- How would you measure whether this design succeeded? (Mention task completion rate, drop-off per step, time to complete, support tickets, app store rating.)
- How do you work with developers at handoff? (Mention Figma dev mode, specs, component naming, design tokens.)
- What would you improve in the MCo-opCash app? **Download it and use it before Thursday.** Note 3 friction points and 3 things it does well.

6. Questions to ask them

- What does the design team look like, and who would I report to?
- Is there a design system in place, or is building one part of the role?
- How are design decisions validated: user testing, analytics, A/B tests?
- What are the next stages after the practical?

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7. Practice before Thursday

Do at least one timed (90-minute) run:

> **Practice brief:** Design a "Send to M-Pesa" flow in the Co-op mobile app for a first-time user, including recipient selection, amount entry, fee display, confirmation, PIN, success, and failure (insufficient funds / network timeout).

Then present it out loud to someone in 5 minutes.